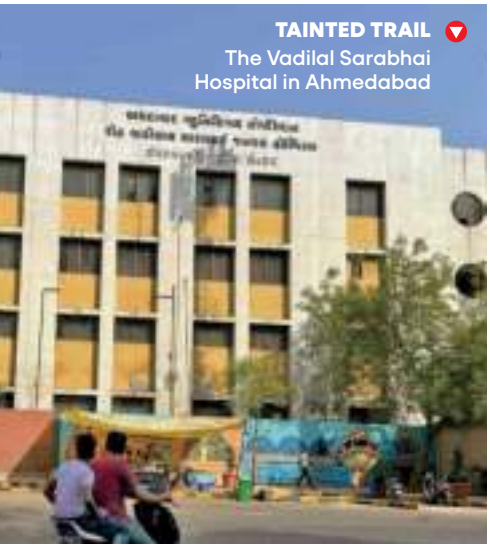
▶ GUJARAT

PATIENTS TURN GUINEA PIGS

A public hospital in Ahmedabad is under a cloud for illegal clinical trials on unwitting patients, with corrupt doctors in cahoots with pharma firms



ALAMY



TAINTED TRAIL
The Vadilal Sarabhai Hospital in Ahmedabad

any video/audio or paper trail recording informed patient consent, let alone counselling related to that.

In February, during the budget session of the Ahmedabad Municipal Corporation (AMC), which runs VSH, Kesari asked commissioner Banchha Nidhi Pani if such trials were on. The answer was no. But Kesari dug deeper and found a whole rodent's warren. She later presented the evidence: MoUs between two pharma firms and VSH's academic arm, NHL Municipal Medical College—signed in November 2024—detailing 25-year agreements. And a document showing the dean appointing associate professor Dr Devang Rana as 'expert pharmacologist' for the purpose.

Hard evidence, so the AMC had to accept it and act. It set up a five-member inquiry committee which, in April, confirmed unauthorised trials were conducted by nine doctors, including Dr Rana and eight contractual physicians. All were suspended. The full list of firms involved has yet to be revealed. Pani told INDIA TODAY "the trials have now stopped" and the case would be taken to its logical end. The panel is now looking to recover the slush money paid into the accounts of doctors and their kin.

TROUBLING OVERSIGHT

But Dr Dilip Mavlankar, former director of the Indian Institute of Public Health, raises questions about the AMC's oversight. Following a 2019 administrative split, VSH had failed to set up its own IEC and instead relied on private committees. The probe is now expected to reveal whether these entities were registered, which would clinch if the trials were indeed illegal. The split also led to a shortage of senior doctors, creating a regulatory void of sorts where pharma agents operated freely. "If trials were not reported in annual reports, it reflects poorly on governance," says Dr Mavlankar.

On April 30, hearing a 2012 PIL on a similar scandal unearthed in Indore that had claimed 32 lives, the Supreme Court directed the Centre to report on the allegations. The next hearing is on July 30. Kesari alleges at least three deaths in the past three months. Pani refutes this, saying she has presented no documentary evidence. Nonetheless, the revelations show how sick the system is. ■

Takeaways

- **In 2021-2024, 500+ patients possibly subjected to illegal clinical trials at VSH**
- **The VSH board members' ignorance about the trials reflects poorly on the hospital's governance**